

A Project Report on
Evolution of Sports Branding and Sports Signage in Modern Sporting Events

Submitted By

Ishani Biswas

Roll No. 20 CLASS TYBSMA SEM VI

For The Degree of

THE BACHELOR OF SPORTS MANAGEMENT

UNIVERSITY OF MUMBAI

Under the Guidance of

Kinjal Mehta

INTERNATIONAL INSTITUTE OF SPORTS & MANAGEMENT

ACADEMIC YEAR 2025–2026

A Project Report on
Evolution of Sports Branding and Sports Signage in Modern Sporting Events

Submitted By

Ishani Biswas

For The Degree of

THE BACHELOR OF SPORTS MANAGEMENT

UNIVERSITY OF MUMBAI

Under the Guidance of

Kinjal Mehta

INTERNATIONAL INSTITUTE OF SPORTS & MANAGEMENT

ACADEMIC YEAR 2025–2026

DECLARATION

I, Ishani Biswas, studying in the Third Year of the Bachelor of Sports Management course in the academic year 2025–2026 at the International Institute of Sports & Management (IISM), hereby declare that the project titled "EVOLUTION OF SPORTS BRANDING AND SPORTS SIGNAGE IN MODERN SPORTING EVENTS" has been completed as part of the course requirements of the Bachelor of Sports Management of the University of Mumbai.

It is further declared that the information presented in this project is true and original to the best of the student's knowledge. The project is an independent academic effort and has not been submitted to any other institution for the award of any degree or diploma.

All sources of secondary data used in the preparation of this project have been duly acknowledged and cited in the APA 7th Edition format. No portion of this project has been copied from any previously submitted work, academic journal, book, or online source without proper citation and attribution.

Date: _____

Place: _____

Ishani Biswas

Class TYBSM Div A Sem VI

Roll No. 20

CERTIFICATE

This is to certify that Ishani Biswas, studying in the Third Year of the Bachelor of Sports Management course at the International Institute of Sports & Management (IISM), has completed the project titled "EVOLUTION OF SPORTS BRANDING AND SPORTS SIGNAGE IN MODERN SPORTING EVENTS" in the academic year 2025–2026.

It is further certified that the information presented in this project is true and original to the best of the guide's knowledge, and that the project is an independent piece of academic work carried out by the student.

Date: _____

Place: _____

Kinjal Mehta

Ms. Avanti Desai

Head-Academics

Mr. Amitava Pal

Associate Dean

[Institute Seal]

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

Sincere gratitude and heartfelt thanks are extended to the Project Guide, Kinjal Mehta Ma'am, International Institute of Sports & Management, for providing unwavering guidance, consistent encouragement and the academic confidence to carry out this study. This project would not have been possible without that sustained support and mentorship.

Appreciation is also extended to the Head-Academics; BSM, Ms. Avanti Desai and the Class In-charges, Ms. Manali Patil and Ms. Priyal Karania of TYBSM, for their kind coordination and timely support throughout the academic year.

The researcher also wishes to thank all colleagues and peers at IISM whose valuable feedback, suggestions and discussions added richness to this study and made the research process a rewarding experience.

Finally, a deep and sincere thanks is owed to family and friends, whose encouragement, patience and unwavering support made the completion of this project possible.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Sr. No.	Particulars	Page No.
	Declaration	1
	Certificate	2
	Acknowledgement	3
	Table of Contents	4 - 6
	List of Tables	7
	Chapter 1 – Introduction	8
1.1	Overview of Modern Sporting Events	8
1.2	Importance of Sports Branding and Signage	9
1.3	Objectives of the Study	9
1.4	Scope and Limitations	10
1.5	Research Methodology	11
	Chapter 2 – Conceptual Framework	12
2.1	Sports Branding – Definition, Elements and Fan Engagement	12-13
2.2	Sports Signage – Definition, Types and Functional Importance	14-15
2.3	Difference Between Sports Branding and Sports Signage	15-17
	Chapter 3 – Evolution of Sports Branding	18
3.1	Early Development of Sports Identity	18
3.2	Rise of Sponsorship and Commercial Branding	19

3.3 Television Era and Brand Expansion	19
3.4 Digital Media and Social Branding	20
3.5 Modern Branding Techniques	21
Chapter 4 – Evolution of Sports Signage	23
4.1 Traditional Stadium Signage	23
4.2 Advertising Boards and Sponsorship Displays	24
4.3 LED and Digital Signage	24-25
4.4 Virtual and Broadcast Signage	26
4.5 Smart and Interactive Signage	27
Chapter 5 – Integration of Branding and Signage	29
5.1 Relationship Between Branding and Signage	29
5.2 Role in Revenue Generation	30
5.3 Impact on Viewer Experience	30-31
Chapter 6 – Case Study: Indian Premier League (IPL)	32
6.1 Overview of the IPL	32
6.2 Evolution of Sports Branding in IPL	33-34
6.3 Evolution of Sports Signage in IPL	35-37
6.4 Gold Coast Sport Signage – BCCI's Central Branding Agency	37
6.5 Impact on Revenue and Fan Engagement	39
6.6 Key Insights	40
Chapter 7 – Case Study: ICC Events	41
7.1 Overview of ICC Tournaments	41

7.2 Branding Strategy in ICC Events	42
7.3 Signage Systems in ICC Events	43
7.4 Global Impact	44-45
Chapter 8 – Case Study: English Premier League (EPL)	46
8.1 Overview of the League	46
8.2 Branding Evolution in Football	47
8.3 Signage Technologies in EPL Stadiums	48
8.4 Virtual Advertising in Football	49-50
Chapter 9 – Comparative Analysis	51
9.1 IPL vs ICC vs Football Leagues – Branding	51
9.2 IPL vs ICC vs Football Leagues – Signage	52
9.3 Key Learnings	54
Chapter 10 – Future Trends	55
10.1 AI and Data-Driven Branding	55
10.2 Virtual and Personalised Advertising	56
10.3 Immersive Fan Experiences (AR / VR)	56-57
Chapter 11 – Conclusion	58
11.1 Summary of Findings	58
11.2 Final Insights	59-60
Bibliography	61-62

LIST OF TABLES

Table 2.1 – Comparison: Sports Branding vs Sports Signage	16
Table 3.1 – Timeline of Sports Branding Evolution	22
Table 4.1 – Comparison of Signage Technologies	27
Table 6.1 – IPL Title Sponsors (2008–2024)	34
Table 6.2 – Key Signage Innovations in IPL	39
Table 7.1 – ICC Event Sponsorship and Branding Overview	42
Table 9.1 – Comparative Analysis: IPL vs ICC vs EPL	53

CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION

1.1 Overview of Modern Sporting Events

Sport has long been more than just a game. Over the decades, what began as simple contests of athletic ability have transformed into multi-billion-dollar spectacles, drawing audiences of hundreds of millions across televisions, smartphones and stadiums around the world. Today a major sporting event such as the Indian Premier League, the ICC Cricket World Cup or the English Premier League is not merely a competition, it is a commercial platform, a cultural festival and a media product all at once.

The scale of this transformation becomes vivid when one considers the numbers. The global sports market, which stood at around USD 108 billion in the year 2000, crossed USD 600 billion by 2024. India alone commands an extraordinary share of this through cricket with the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) recognised as one of the wealthiest sports governing bodies in the world. The Indian Premier League launched in 2008 redefined what a domestic cricket league could be commercially, turning franchise cricket into a product worth billions.

At the heart of this commercial transformation lie two disciplines that are often spoken of in the same breath but are distinctly different in nature; sports branding and sports signage. Together they form the visible and strategic layer through which sporting events communicate their identity, attract sponsors and generate revenue. Understanding how these two disciplines have evolved is central to understanding the modern sports industry.

1.2 Importance of Sports Branding and Signage

Sports branding is the practice of creating, managing and communicating the identity of a sport, team, event or athlete in the commercial marketplace. It is the reason a cricket fan feels a strong sense of identity with the Mumbai Indians or why a football supporter around the world instantly recognises the red jersey of Manchester United. Branding in sport goes far beyond logos and colours it encompasses the values, stories and emotional connections that make fans loyal and sponsors eager to associate.

Sports signage on the other hand is the infrastructure that makes branding visible within and around sporting environments. It is the perimeter board at a cricket ground carrying a sponsor's logo, the LED screen behind the stumps flashing between deliveries, the branded dugout where players sit, the backdrops behind the interviews and the virtual advertisement that appears on a viewer's television but does not physically exist on the field. Signage is the physical and digital delivery mechanism through which brand messages reach audiences.

The evolution of both disciplines is deeply intertwined. As branding strategies became more sophisticated, signage technology had to evolve to keep up. As signage technology advanced, it opened new possibilities for how brands could be deployed in sporting spaces. This study traces that journey, from the hand-painted boards of the early twentieth century to the AI-powered, geographically targeted virtual signage systems of today.

1.3 Objectives of the Study

The present study is guided by the following specific objectives:

- To clearly define and distinguish between sports branding and sports signage, establishing each as a distinct but interconnected discipline within sports management.

- To trace the historical evolution of sports branding, from early club identity systems to the sophisticated, multi-platform brand strategies of the contemporary era.
- To document the evolution of sports signage technology, from static painted boards through LED perimeter systems to virtual and augmented reality signage.
- To examine through detailed case studies of the IPL, ICC events and the English Premier League, how branding and signage have been integrated in practice to drive commercial outcomes.
- To highlight the role of specialised branding agencies, specifically Gold Coast Sport Signage, in shaping the modern signage and branding landscape in Indian cricket.
- To identify future trends and emerging technologies that will shape sports branding and signage in the years ahead.

1.4 Scope and Limitations

The scope of this study encompasses the global sports industry, with a particular emphasis on cricket (IPL and ICC events) and association football (the English Premier League). While examples and references are drawn from other sports where relevant, the three case studies selected provide the most comprehensive and commercially significant examples of sports branding and signage evolution available.

The study is based entirely on secondary data. Primary data collection through surveys or interviews has not been undertaken, as the existing body of secondary literature, industry reports, and publicly available documentation is sufficiently rich to address the stated objectives. This represents both a methodological choice and a practical limitation, the depth of first-hand industry insights available through primary research is not replicated here.

A further limitation is that the sports branding and signage industry evolves rapidly, and some developments described as emerging at the time of writing may have progressed further by the time this study is reviewed. Every effort has been made to draw upon the most recent available secondary sources.

1.5 Research Methodology

This study employs a descriptive research design based entirely on secondary data. The researcher has drawn information from academic journals, industry publications, sports management textbooks, official league and governing body communications, business media reports, and credible online sources.

Secondary data sources include reports from Nielsen Sports, Deloitte Sports, SportsPro Media, the International Cricket Council, the Board of Control for Cricket in India, the Premier League, and Statista. Academic literature cited includes works from the Journal of Sport Management, the Journal of Sponsorship, and the International Journal of Sports Marketing and Sponsorship.

All secondary information has been critically reviewed, synthesised and presented in the researcher's own words in accordance with the academic integrity guidelines of the International Institute of Sports & Management. References are cited in APA 7th Edition format throughout.

CHAPTER 2: CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK

2.1 Sports Branding – Definition, Key Elements and Fan Engagement

2.1.1 Definition and Meaning

Sports branding refers to the strategic process of creating, developing and managing a distinct and recognisable identity for a sports entity be it a team, league, athlete or event; in a way that differentiates it from competitors, resonates with target audiences, and creates sustained commercial value. It is at its core, the application of brand management principles to the unique and emotionally charged world of sport.

Mullin, Hardy and Sutton (2014) define sports marketing as the process of designing and implementing activities for the production, pricing, promotion, and distribution of a sports product to satisfy the needs or desires of consumers and to achieve the company's objectives. Within this broader framework, sports branding occupies the identity-building function; answering the question of what a sports entity stands for, how it looks and what it means to its audience.

Unlike conventional product brands, sports brands operate in an environment defined by unpredictability and intense emotional investment. A sports team may win or lose, a star player may be injured or transferred yet strong sports brands consistently maintain and even grow their equity through the loyalty and emotional identification of their fan communities. This resilience is one of the most remarkable and commercially significant characteristics of the sports brand.

2.1.2 Key Elements of Sports Branding

The key elements that constitute a sports brand include the visual identity system (logos, colours, typography, kit design), the brand name and its associated heritage, the brand narrative (the story and values the entity represents) athlete and personality associations, fan community and culture, and the commercial partnerships that the brand has built. Each of these elements contributes to what brand theorists call brand equity, the overall value that a brand holds in the minds of its audiences.

Aaker's (1991) model of brand equity identifies brand awareness, brand associations, perceived quality and brand loyalty as the four dimensions through which brand equity is built and measured. In the sports context, Gladden and Funk (2002) extended this framework by identifying sport-specific associations including team success, star players, head coach reputation, stadium environment and tradition as drivers of fan brand attachment. Their research confirmed that fans who develop strong associations with a sports brand tend to remain loyal even during periods of on-field underperformance.

2.1.3 Role in Fan Engagement

The relationship between sports branding and fan engagement is reciprocal. Strong branding drives deeper fan engagement by giving supporters a clear identity to align with, stories to invest in, and experiences to share. At the same time, engaged fans amplify the brand through word-of-mouth, social media participation and merchandise purchases, creating a virtuous cycle of brand growth.

In the digital era, this relationship has taken on new dimensions. Social media platforms have transformed fans from passive consumers of sports content into active co-creators of the brand narrative. A well-managed sports brand in the contemporary landscape must therefore attend not only to the professional quality of its visual identity and commercial partnerships, but also to the authentic, participatory culture it cultivates across digital platforms. The Indian Premier League

provides a masterclass in this regard, having built one of the most digitally engaged sports fan communities in the world.

2.2 Sports Signage – Definition, Types and Functional Importance

2.2.1 Definition and Meaning

Sports signage refers to the physical and digital display systems used within and around sporting venues and broadcasts to communicate brand, directional, informational and commercial messages to audiences. It is the visible, tangible layer of commercial communication that sponsors, teams and event organisers deploy to reach spectators, both those present in the stadium and the vastly larger audiences consuming the event through television and digital media.

While sports branding defines what a brand is and what it stands for, sports signage defines where and how that brand appears in the sporting environment. Signage is the execution medium the canvas upon which branding is painted and through which sponsor exposure is delivered. It is fundamentally a media channel and like all media channels, its value is measured in terms of the audience impressions it delivers and the commercial returns those impressions generate.

2.2.2 Types of Sports Signage

Sports signage can be classified into several distinct categories based on technology and deployment. Static signage includes painted walls, vinyl hoardings, printed banners and backlit panels; the earliest and most basic form of venue advertising. Electronic and LED signage encompasses digital scoreboards, LED perimeter boards and giant video screens that deliver dynamic, rotating content in real time. Virtual signage involves the digital overlay of brand images onto the television broadcast through camera-tracking technology, making advertisements visible only to the TV audience and not physically present in the venue. Broadcast-integrated signage includes stump branding, boundary rope branding and on-pitch

graphic overlays that are specifically designed for maximum visibility in broadcast camera angles. Ambient and experiential signage covers branded fan zones, dugout branding, player tunnel graphics and other installations that create brand immersion across the event environment.

2.2.3 Functional Importance

The functional importance of sports signage in the modern sporting event can hardly be overstated. For sponsors, signage is the primary vehicle through which they achieve brand exposure and communicate with the sports audience. For rights-holders; teams, leagues and governing bodies; signage inventory is a core commercial asset, the sale of which generates significant revenue. For broadcasters, signage contributes to the visual richness and commercial density of the broadcast product. And for fans, well-designed signage enhances the atmosphere and visual experience of attending or watching a sporting event.

2.3 Difference Between Sports Branding and Sports Signage

2.3.1 Conceptual Differences

The most fundamental conceptual difference between sports branding and sports signage lies in their level of abstraction. Sports branding is a strategic and identity-based discipline; it concerns itself with what an entity means, who it speaks to and how it positions itself in the emotional and commercial landscape of sport. Sports signage is an operational and executional discipline, it concerns itself with how brand messages are physically or digitally displayed in sporting environments.

To use a simple analogy; if a brand were a person, branding would be that person's character, values and reputation, while signage would be the clothes they wear and the spaces they occupy. Both are important and closely related, but they operate at different levels and involve different skill sets.

2.3.2 Functional Differences

Functionally, sports branding is the responsibility of marketing strategists, brand managers, creative agencies and communications teams. It involves decisions about positioning, messaging, visual identity and long-term brand architecture. Sports signage, on the other hand, is the domain of operational teams, event production specialists, broadcast engineers and signage technology providers. It involves decisions about placement, format, technology, content scheduling and measurement.

In practice, the two disciplines must work in close coordination. The brand strategy must inform the signage deployment, ensuring that the right brand messages appear in the right spaces, in the right format, for the right audiences. And the signage capability must inform the brand strategy, understanding what is technically possible in a given venue or broadcast environment shapes what can be commercially promised to sponsors.

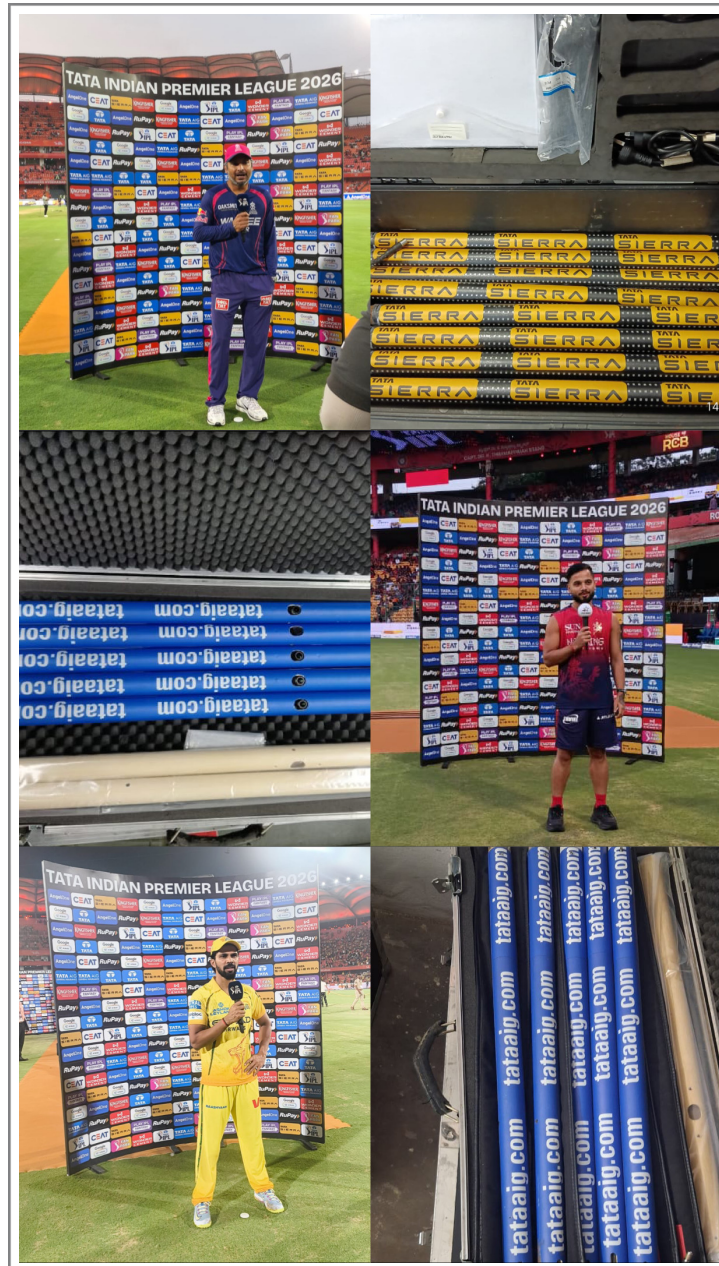
2.3.3 Comparative Table

Table 2.1: Comparison – Sports Branding vs Sports Signage

Parameter	Sports Branding	Sports Signage
Definition	Identity and positioning of a sports entity	Physical/digital display of brand messages in venues
Primary Focus	What the brand is and means	Where and how the brand appears
Nature	Strategic and intangible	Operational and tangible/digital
Key Professionals	Brand managers, marketing agencies	Event producers, tech providers, broadcast engineers
Output	Brand identity, fan loyalty, equity	Visible displays, sponsor exposure, impressions
Measurement	Brand equity, fan surveys, recall studies	Broadcast seconds, audience reach, EAV

Parameter	Sports Branding	Sports Signage
Examples	IPL franchise identities, athlete endorsements	LED perimeter boards, virtual stumps, dugout branding

Source: Researcher's own compilation based on secondary literature



CHAPTER 3: EVOLUTION OF SPORTS BRANDING

3.1 Early Development of Sports Identity

The origins of sports branding lie in the simple need for identification. Long before commercial imperatives entered the picture, sports teams required visual markers that allowed players, officials, and spectators to tell sides apart. Colours, crests, and nicknames were the earliest tools of what would eventually become sports branding. In the late nineteenth century, the formation of professional football clubs in England and cricket clubs across the British Empire was accompanied by the adoption of distinct team colours and badges; rudimentary visual identities that served a functional rather than commercial purpose.

These early identities were deeply rooted in community and geography. A cricket club's colours or a football club's crest reflected the town, factory, or school from which it had sprung. The emotional connection that supporters developed with these symbols was organic and grassroots ; not designed by marketing agencies but grown through years of shared experience and local pride. This organic fan identification, while pre-commercial in origin, laid the foundation for the enormous brand equity that the most successful sports teams command today.

The commercialisation of these identities began gradually in the early twentieth century, as professional sport attracted paying spectators and, eventually, media attention. Newspapers were the first mass medium to amplify sports identities beyond their local communities, and with larger audiences came larger commercial opportunities. However, the truly transformative period for sports branding lay ahead, waiting for the arrival of television.

3.2 Rise of Sponsorship and Commercial Branding

The first systematic commercial exploitation of sports brands came through sponsorship; the association of corporate names and products with sporting events and entities in exchange for financial support. Early sponsorships in cricket and motor racing in the 1960s and 1970s marked the beginning of what would become a multi-billion-dollar industry. Tobacco companies were among the first major commercial entrants into sports sponsorship, recognising that association with the glamour, excitement and healthy image of sport was a powerful tool for their marketing communications.

The transformation of Formula One motor racing in the late 1960s into a rolling advertising billboard with team liveries and driver overalls carrying prominent sponsor branding; is often cited as the moment when sports sponsorship came of age as a commercial discipline. The Lotus team's adoption of Imperial Tobacco's Gold Leaf livery in 1968 was a watershed moment, demonstrating that sports could serve as an advertising medium in its own right. This model was quickly adopted across other sports, laying the groundwork for the global sponsorship industry that exists today.

In cricket, the shift toward commercial branding took longer but was equally transformative when it arrived. The Kerry Packer revolution of the late 1970s, which introduced coloured clothing and night cricket to the sport, was driven in large part by television and commercial considerations. It represented the first major break from cricket's traditional resistance to commercialisation and set in motion a process that would culminate, three decades later, in the IPL.

3.3 Television Era and Brand Expansion

Television was the single most important driver of sports brand expansion in the twentieth century. By creating large, passive, commercially attractive audiences for sports events,

television transformed the economic calculus of sport entirely. The rights to broadcast major sporting events became enormously valuable properties, contested fiercely by networks willing to pay escalating fees for the privilege of delivering sports audiences to advertisers.

This commercial environment created strong incentives for sports organisations to invest in their brands. A well-recognised, commercially attractive sports brand could command higher broadcast rights fees, attract premium sponsors, and generate merchandise revenue from a global rather than merely local fan base. The English Premier League launched in its modern form in 1992 with a landmark television rights deal, became the defining model of how television-driven brand expansion could transform a sports league into a global commercial phenomenon.

The globalisation of sports brands through television also created the conditions for athlete branding to emerge as a major commercial phenomenon. Cricketers like Sachin Tendulkar, footballers like David Beckham and basketball players like Michael Jordan became global brand properties, their faces and personalities worth hundreds of millions of dollars in endorsement value. The athlete brand as a concept was born from and sustained by the mass media exposure that television provided.

3.4 Digital Media and Social Branding

The emergence of the internet and subsequently social media, introduced a new era of sports branding characterised by direct, two-way interaction between sports brands and their fans. Where television had been a one-way broadcast medium, social media platforms such as Twitter, Instagram, Facebook and YouTube created environments in which fans could engage with sports brands in real time, respond to events as they unfolded, and participate in the creation and spread of brand narratives.

This shift had profound implications for how sports brands were managed. The carefully controlled, professionally crafted brand communications of the television era gave way to a more fluid, responsive and participatory brand environment. An ill-judged social media post could damage a brand overnight whereas an authentic, engaging piece of content could reach millions at virtually zero cost. Sports brands that adapted quickly to this new environment; learning to be authentic, responsive and entertaining across digital channels; gained significant competitive advantages.

In India, the digital transformation of sports branding has been accelerated by the extraordinary reach of smartphones and mobile data. The IPL's partnership with Disney+ Hotstar created one of the world's largest sports streaming audiences, fundamentally changing the relationship between the IPL brand and its fans. With digital streaming comes a wealth of audience data; who is watching, where they are, how they engage; that has enabled far more targeted and personalised brand communications than were ever possible in the broadcast era.

3.5 Modern Branding Techniques

Modern sports branding is a sophisticated, multi-layered discipline that draws on tools and techniques from across the marketing, design, technology and data analytics domains. At its foundation, modern sports branding begins with rigorous brand strategy; a clear articulation of the brand's positioning, values, target audiences and competitive differentiation. This strategy informs everything from the visual identity to the content calendar to the sponsorship partner selection.

Visual identity design in modern sports branding has reached new levels of sophistication with major sports franchises investing heavily in brand refresh projects that update their logos, colour palettes and kit designs to remain relevant in a visually crowded marketplace. The rebranding of IPL franchises over the years; updated logos, revised colour systems, new jersey designs;

reflects the importance sports organisations now attach to maintaining a contemporary and commercially attractive visual identity.

Athlete branding has become a specialised sub-discipline, with top athletes employing dedicated brand managers, social media teams, and marketing agencies to build and monetise their personal brands. Players like Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma are brand properties worth hundreds of crores in endorsement value, their personal brand identities carefully cultivated and commercially managed to maximise their appeal to sponsors across multiple categories.

Table 3.1: Timeline of Sports Branding Evolution

Era	Period	Key Development	Commercial Impact
Pre-Commercial	Pre-1950s	Club colours, crests, nicknames	Community identity, no major revenue
Sponsorship Era	1960s–1970s	Corporate sponsorship of events and kits	New revenue streams for sports entities
Television Era	1980s–1990s	Mass broadcast audiences, rights fees	Global brand reach, athlete endorsements
Globalisation	1995–2010	International leagues, satellite TV	Cross-border fan bases, franchise models
Digital Era	2010–Present	Social media, streaming, data analytics	Two-way fan engagement, personalised branding

Source: Researcher's own compilation from secondary literature

CHAPTER 4: EVOLUTION OF SPORTS SIGNAGE

4.1 Traditional Stadium Signage

The history of sports signage begins simply enough with paint. The earliest commercial signs at sporting venues were hand-painted on walls, fences and boards around cricket grounds and football stadiums in England and Australia in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. These were modest affairs; a local merchant's name, a tobacco brand, a hotel advertisement; but they established the fundamental commercial model that would eventually grow into a global industry. Space within a sporting venue visible to a captive audience had commercial value.

Through the first half of the twentieth century static signage dominated the sporting landscape. Painted boards and printed banners were erected around the perimeters of playing surfaces on the facades of grandstands and above terraces. The content was unchangeable once installed, limiting the commercial flexibility available to venue operators. A single sponsor's message occupied a given space for the duration of an event season and the revenue generated while welcome was modest by contemporary standards.

Despite its limitations, traditional static signage established certain principles that remain fundamental to sports signage practice today. The concept of perimeter placement, positioning advertising boards around the boundary of the playing surface at a height and angle that ensures maximum visibility to the television camera, was developed during this era and continues to define the geometry of sports signage layouts at all levels of the game.

4.2 Advertising Boards and Sponsorship Displays

The formalisation of sports sponsorship from the 1960s onwards brought a new level of commercial rigour to venue signage. As corporate sponsors began to invest significant sums in sports sponsorship, they required professional management of their brand visibility within event environments. This drove the development of more structured and systematically managed signage programmes, with defined categories of inventory; perimeter boards, outfield signage, FOP branding, player kit branding, scoreboard advertising each assigned a commercial value and sold accordingly.

In cricket, the introduction of One Day International cricket in the 1970s and 1980s created a more commercially amenable format for sponsorship display. The shorter format, with its defined time frame and guaranteed broadcast slot, was easier to package commercially than Test cricket. Advertisers could predict their exposure windows and the growing television audiences for ODI cricket made the exposure increasingly valuable. The placement of sponsor logos on playing equipment like bats, helmets, kit bags and on boundary boards around the ground became standard practice.

The backlit panel introduced as a more visible and premium alternative to printed boards, represented the first significant technological upgrade in sports venue advertising since the hand-painted sign. Backlit panels offered superior visibility in low-light conditions and a higher quality visual impression, commanding a price premium over standard printed boards. They also required more sophisticated installation and management, marking the beginning of the specialisation of the sports signage sector.

4.3 LED and Digital Signage

The introduction of LED technology into sports venue advertising constituted the most transformative technological advance in sports signage since the invention of the advertising

board itself. LED displays offered capabilities that were fundamentally impossible with any prior technology; the ability to display moving images and video to change content in real time to operate at very high brightness levels suitable for outdoor use, and to rotate multiple sponsor messages within a single advertising cycle.

The commercial implications of LED perimeter boards were enormous. Where a static or backlit board could carry only one sponsor's message at a given location an LED system could display a sequence of eight, ten or even more different sponsor messages within the timeframe of a single over in cricket. This effectively multiplied the commercial inventory available for sale at a given venue without requiring any additional physical space; a pure efficiency gain that transformed the revenue potential of sports venue advertising.

LED technology also enabled the synchronisation of in-venue advertising with broadcast schedules. Sophisticated LED systems can be programmed to display specific messages when the television camera is directed at the relevant section of perimeter board, maximising the broadcast exposure associated with each sponsor message. This capability; knowing precisely when each sponsor's message is likely to be captured by the television camera and programming the display cycle accordingly is now a standard feature of premium sports venue signage systems.

Giant video screens, the large format LED displays installed at the ends of sports grounds to show replays, live feeds and entertainment content; have also become a defining feature of the modern stadium experience. These screens serve both an audience engagement function (giving spectators who are far from the action a clear view of key moments) and a commercial function (displaying sponsor branding and advertising content between passages of play). Their scale and prominence make them one of the most commercially valuable pieces of signage real estate in any stadium.

4.4 Virtual and Broadcast Signage

Virtual signage represents a paradigm shift in the fundamental concept of sports advertising. Rather than deploying physical displays within the venue, virtual signage uses camera-tracking technology and digital image processing to overlay computer-generated brand imagery onto the live television broadcast. The result is brand messages that are perfectly visible to the television audience but are entirely absent from the physical environment of the venue.

This technology, first deployed commercially in cricket broadcasts in the mid-2000s, has profound implications for the economics of sports signage. Because different digital overlays can be inserted for different regional audiences watching the same broadcast, virtual signage effectively enables rights-holders to sell the same physical space to multiple sponsors simultaneously; one brand visible to Indian viewers, another to viewers in the United Kingdom, and a third to audiences in the Middle East. This geographic targeting capability dramatically expands the commercial yield of the underlying signage inventory.

In Indian cricket, virtual signage has become an especially powerful commercial tool given the enormous premium that the Indian broadcast audience commands relative to other markets. The same square metre of virtual signage space visible during an India cricket broadcast is worth multiples of what it would generate in almost any other market, reflecting the extraordinary commercial value of the Indian cricket television audience. Rights-holders have been able to leverage this differential to generate revenue from multiple international sponsors simultaneously.

Stump branding and LED stumps represent a particularly interesting and cricket-specific form of broadcast-integrated signage. The playing stumps, positioned at the centre of the television camera's field of view during every delivery bowled, offer premium visibility in every broadcast frame. LED stumps, which illuminate when the bails are dislodged and can carry animated brand content, have become one of the most visually distinctive and commercially valuable pieces of

equipment branding in the game. The Zing wickets, introduced in international cricket, transformed stumps from purely functional equipment into a dynamic, attention-grabbing commercial canvas.

4.5 Smart and Interactive Signage

The most recent phase of sports signage evolution involves the integration of data, connectivity, and interactivity into the signage experience. Smart signage systems are capable of responding in real time to match situations, crowd demographics, and broadcast data, automatically selecting the most commercially appropriate content for display at any given moment. An LED perimeter board in a smart stadium might, for instance, automatically switch to displaying a beverage brand's advertising when temperature data indicates it is unusually hot or display content in a particular language when crowd analytics suggest a high proportion of international visitors.

Augmented Reality (AR) applications on smartphones are beginning to create new interactive signage possibilities, allowing fans in the stadium to point their devices at specific locations and receive overlay information; player statistics, sponsor offers, interactive games; that enhances their experience and creates additional brand engagement touchpoints. While still in their early stages, these technologies point toward a future in which the boundary between physical signage and digital experience is entirely dissolved.

Table 4.1: Comparison of Signage Technologies in Sport

Technology	Period	Key Feature	Commercial Capability
Static/Painted	Pre-1980s	Fixed, single-message display	One sponsor per space
Backlit Panels	1980s	Illuminated, higher visibility	Premium placement pricing

Technology	Period	Key Feature	Commercial Capability
LED Perimeter	1990s–2000s	Dynamic, rotating content	Multiple sponsors per space, real-time updates
Giant Video Screens	2000s	Video and live replay	High-impact brand content
Virtual Signage	2005–Present	TV overlay, geotargeted	Same space, multiple markets simultaneously
LED Stumps/Equipment	2010s	Broadcast-integrated LED	Premium visibility in broadcast frame
Smart/AR Signage	2020s–Present	Data-driven, interactive	Personalised, dynamic, immersive

Source: Researcher's own compilation from secondary data (Desbordes & Richelieu, 2012; SportsPro, 2023)



CHAPTER 5: INTEGRATION OF BRANDING AND SIGNAGE

5.1 Relationship Between Branding and Signage

Sports branding and sports signage, while conceptually distinct are functionally inseparable in the context of a modern sporting event. The brand strategy defines what needs to be communicated; the identity, the values, the sponsor messages. The signage system determines how, where and to whom those communications are delivered. One without the other is incomplete: a powerful brand strategy with inadequate signage infrastructure leaves commercial value unrealised; a sophisticated signage system deployed without a coherent brand strategy lacks the direction needed to generate meaningful returns.

The most successful sports properties in the world; the IPL, the FIFA World Cup, the English Premier League are those that have achieved the tightest integration between their branding and signage strategies. Their brand guidelines govern not just logo usage and colour application but extend to defining how every surface within the event environment; from the perimeter boards to the player dugouts to the virtual overlays contributes to the overall brand experience. Signage becomes an expression of the brand rather than merely an advertising platform attached to it.

Gold Coast Sport Signage, which serves as the BCCI's central branding agency and has been instrumental in transforming the visual environment of Indian cricket, operates precisely at this intersection of branding and signage. The company's work involves from perimeter boards to stump branding to dugout set up to big screen branding and full stadium branding including franchise concourse branding tells a coherent commercial story that serves both the event brand and the sponsor brands it carries.

5.2 Role in Revenue Generation

The commercial significance of integrated branding and signage is most evident in the revenue it generates. For a major cricket tournament like the IPL, signage-related revenue; encompassing perimeter board rights, stump sponsorship, LED panel packages, virtual signage agreements and venue branding packages; constitutes a substantial portion of the total commercial income of the event. Rights-holders that manage their signage inventory professionally and integrate it coherently with their brand strategy can command significant premium pricing from sponsors.

The shift from static to LED and virtual signage has dramatically increased the total commercial yield of sports venue advertising. Where a traditional static-board venue might support three to five perimeter sponsors, a fully LED-equipped venue with virtual signage capability can support fifteen or more sponsor brands across different categories without the visual environment feeling cluttered or commercially compromised. This inventory multiplication is one of the most important commercial innovations in modern sports signage.

5.3 Impact on Viewer Experience

Beyond its commercial functions, the quality of branding and signage in a sporting event has a significant impact on the experience of both in-venue spectators and television audiences. Well-designed, professionally executed signage enhances the visual richness and production quality of a sporting event. Poorly conceived or cluttered signage, on the other hand, detracts from the visual experience and can undermine the audience's engagement with the event itself.

The evolution of sports signage has consistently been guided by the imperative to enhance rather than distract from the spectator experience. LED technology, when properly managed, allows for dynamic visual content that adds energy and excitement to the stadium atmosphere. Virtual signage when deployed tastefully is seamlessly integrated into the broadcast without creating

jarring visual interruptions. The best sports signage is the kind that sponsors and audiences barely notice as advertising, it simply feels like an integral part of the event environment.



CHAPTER 6: CASE STUDY 1 – INDIAN PREMIER LEAGUE (IPL)

6.1 Overview of the IPL

Few sporting properties in the world have achieved the kind of commercial transformation in such a short span of time as the Indian Premier League. Launched by the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) in 2008, the IPL took a cricketing format Twenty20 or T20 that had previously been regarded as entertainment rather than serious sport and turned it into the most commercially valuable domestic cricket league in the world. By 2023, the IPL was valued at approximately USD 10.7 billion a figure that places it in the same tier as some of the world's most established sports leagues.

The league's structure is eight to ten city-based franchises each with their own brand identity, fan base and commercial ecosystem was modelled on the North American franchise sports model and was a deliberate commercial design choice. By creating independent franchise brands, the BCCI ensured that the IPL had multiple commercially attractive properties within a single league, each capable of generating its own sponsorship and merchandise revenue in addition to the central league revenue pool.

The IPL's commercial success rests on four pillars: broadcasting rights (which alone generated INR 48,390 crore for the 2023–2027 cycle), franchise fees and central sponsorship, individual franchise commercial revenues and an increasingly sophisticated digital media presence. Branding and signage are integral to each of these pillars serving as the delivery mechanism through which sponsors receive the exposure that justifies their investment.

6.2 Evolution of Sports Branding in IPL

6.2.1 Team Branding and Identity

The franchise branding of IPL teams is one of the most commercially sophisticated exercises in sports identity management in India. Each franchise was required to develop a complete brand identity such as name, logo, colours, mascot and team personality that would resonate with fans in its home city and beyond. The original eight franchises including Mumbai Indians, Chennai Super Kings, Kolkata Knight Riders, Royal Challengers Bangalore and others developed identities that have since become among the most recognised sports brands in the country.

Mumbai Indians owned by Reliance Industries became a benchmark for franchise brand management. The blue and gold colour scheme, the distinctive 'MI' logo and the association with Mumbai's cosmopolitan ambition created a brand that transcended cricket and became a cultural symbol for the city. The franchise's consistent on-field success five IPL titles further strengthened its brand equity, demonstrating the relationship between sporting performance and brand value.

Chennai Super Kings, despite being suspended from the league for two years between 2016 and 2017, returned to competition with their fan loyalty essentially undimmed; a remarkable testament to the depth of the brand equity they had built. The yellow jersey, the captain's persona and the 'Whistle Podu' fan culture created a brand that fans identified with at a deeper level than mere sporting allegiance.

6.2.2 Sponsorship Ecosystem

The IPL's sponsorship ecosystem is among the most commercially sophisticated in world sport. It operates across multiple tiers: the title sponsor (currently TATA Group, with a deal worth a reported INR 670 crore per season), official sponsors, strategic time-out partners, associate sponsors and a range of category-specific partners covering everything from beverages and

automobiles to mobile phones and financial services. Each sponsor receives a defined package of brand visibility entitlements, of which signage is a major component.

Table 6.1: IPL Title Sponsors (2008–2024)

Season	Title Sponsor	Deal Value (approx.)	Remarks
2008–2012	DLF	INR 200 crore/year	Inaugural title sponsor
2013–2015	Pepsi	INR 396 crore/year	Increased commercial value
2016–2017	Vivo	INR 100 crore/year	Reduced due to league disruption
2018–2019	Vivo	INR 440 crore/year	New deal, significant increase
2020	Dream11	INR 222 crore (1 yr)	Emergency replacement during COVID
2021–2022	Vivo (then TATA)	INR 440 / 670 crore	TATA took over from mid-2022
2023–2027	TATA Group	INR 670 crore/year	Current, highest-value title deal

Source: Compiled from ESPNcricinfo, BCCI official communications, Business Standard (2024)

6.2.3 Digital and Fan Engagement

The IPL was among the first sports leagues in India to recognise and invest heavily in digital fan engagement as a brand-building tool. The league's official app, social media channels and streaming partnerships; particularly with Star Sports and Disney+ Hotstar have created a digital ecosystem that allows fans to engage with the IPL brand year-round, not just during the two-month season. Content including behind-the-scenes footage, player interviews, fantasy cricket and interactive polls has extended the brand's relationship with fans beyond match broadcasts.

The IPL's social media following across platforms runs into hundreds of millions making it one of the most-followed sports entities on social media in Asia. This digital reach is itself a commercial asset as it enables the IPL and its franchises to offer sponsors digital brand exposure that complements and in some respects exceeds the value of traditional signage and broadcast exposure.

6.3 Evolution of Sports Signage in IPL

6.3.1 Static to LED Boards

When the IPL launched in 2008, the signage infrastructure of Indian cricket grounds was already more sophisticated than it had been a decade earlier, but still limited by contemporary global standards. Static hoardings and basic electronic boards were the norm at most venues. The IPL's launch and the enormous commercial interest it generated, provided both the incentive and the funding to accelerate a significant upgrade in stadium signage infrastructure across the country.

The transition to full LED perimeter systems at major IPL venues was driven by the recognition that LED technology was essential to maximise the commercial value of the league's signage inventory. A static board can carry one sponsor; an LED board can carry fifteen in rotation. In a league with the IPL's sponsorship density there are multiple title, official, strategic and associate partners all requiring defined broadcast visibility LED technology was not a luxury but a commercial necessity.

Today all major IPL venues including the Wankhede Stadium in Mumbai, the M. A. Chidambaram Stadium in Chennai, the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium in Bengaluru and the Narendra Modi Stadium in Ahmedabad are equipped with full-perimeter LED systems capable of delivering dynamic, synchronised, broadcast-optimised signage content. The quality of these installations is comparable to the best stadium signage systems anywhere in the world.

6.3.2 Central Branding – Stumps, Boundary, and Dugouts

The most distinctive and cricket-specific signage developments in the IPL have occurred not at the perimeter but at the centre of the action; in the stumps, the boundary rope and the player dugouts. These areas, all highly visible in the broadcast camera frame and have been transformed from functional necessities into sophisticated commercial and branding canvases.

Stump branding has evolved from simple painted logos on wooden stumps to elaborate LED stump systems. The Zing wicket system, used in international cricket and the IPL features stumps and bails embedded with LED lights that illuminate brilliantly when the bails are dislodged. Beyond their functional role (making dismissals more visually clear), these LED stumps carry sponsor branding in both their resting and activated states. The brand on the stumps is among the highest-value pieces of signage real estate in any IPL broadcast, given the camera's constant focus on the playing area.

The boundary rope, the physical marker delineating the boundary of the playing field is branded with sponsor logos at regular intervals ensuring constant presence in wide-angle broadcast shots. The rope branding combined with the perimeter LED boards positioned behind it, creates layers of brand visibility that are carefully coordinated to avoid visual conflict while maximising commercial density.

Perhaps the most visible transformation in recent IPL signage has been the evolution of the player dugout. In the early years of the IPL, player dugouts were functional but unremarkable; rows of seating under a shelter, distinguished from ordinary spectator seating primarily by their proximity to the playing surface. Over the years, IPL dugouts have been progressively transformed into premium branded environments.

Modern IPL dugouts feature custom-designed, ergonomic game chairs often comparable in quality to premium gaming or esports chairs that carry sponsor branding and contribute to the

overall visual appeal of the dugout environment. The entire dugout area, including the seating, the back wall and the overhead canopy is treated as a branded space with coordinated sponsor logos and colour schemes that make the dugout itself a highly recognisable visual element of the broadcast. When television cameras cut to show reactions in the dugout as they frequently do during key moments of a match the entire branded environment is visible to audiences of hundreds of millions.

6.3.3 Broadcast-Integrated Signage

The IPL has been at the forefront of deploying virtual and broadcast-integrated signage in Indian cricket. Virtual signage technology which overlays digital brand images onto the live broadcast without physical presence in the venue has been used extensively in IPL coverage to deliver geographically targeted advertising to different viewing markets. This is particularly valuable given that the IPL is broadcast to audiences across India, Southeast Asia, the Middle East, the United Kingdom and beyond each market representing a different set of sponsors and different commercial value.

The pitch and outfield areas adjacent to the wicket are also used for digital graphic overlays sponsor logos and messages that appear on the viewer's screen during breaks in play, strategic time-outs and drinks intervals. These overlays while entirely digital are designed to appear as if they are painted onto the playing surface, creating a seamless visual integration with the physical environment that makes them feel natural to the viewer.

6.4 Gold Coast Sport Signage – BCCI's Central Branding Agency

No account of the evolution of sports signage and branding in Indian cricket would be complete without reference to Gold Coast Sport Signage, the company that has served as the central branding agency for the BCCI and has played a decisive role in transforming the visual and commercial environment of Indian cricket over the past decade. Gold Coast occupies a unique

position at the intersection of sports branding and signage; a company that does not merely install boards but designs and delivers entire branded environments for cricket events.

Gold Coast Sport Signage's work for the BCCI encompasses the full spectrum of event branding and signage services. The company is responsible for the design and production of all central BCCI branding elements such as perimeter boards, stump branding, boundary rope branding, dugout installations, outfield branding, and digital contents for Press Conference LED strip as well as the backdrop attached to it; as well as the logistical management of deploying these elements across the multiple venues used in a single tournament. The scale of this undertaking is considerable, requiring coordination across dozens of venues, hundreds of match days and multiple sponsor categories simultaneously.

Among the specific innovations that Gold Coast has introduced or deployed in Indian cricket are the LED stump systems that illuminate on dismissal, the custom-designed player dugout environments featuring premium branded seating, the wide perimeter board set up behind the LED panel boundary and the integrated central branding packages that ensure visual consistency across all venues in a tournament. These innovations have raised the visual quality and commercial sophistication of BCCI events to internationally competitive standards.

Gold Coast's central branding mandate for the BCCI also means that it coordinates the visual environment in which all IPL and Indian national team sponsors appear. This requires careful management of competing sponsor interests, ensuring that each sponsor's branding is clearly visible and not visually compromised by adjacency to a competing brand also while maintaining the overall visual coherence and quality of the event environment. This is a complex and commercially sensitive task that Gold Coast executes across a volume of matches and venues that has no parallel in any other cricket market.

6.5 Impact on Revenue and Fan Engagement

The commercial impact of the IPL's integrated branding and signage strategy has been extraordinary by any measure. The league's total commercial revenues have grown from approximately INR 2,000 crore in its first season to over INR 15,000 crore in 2023, with signage and in-venue branding rights constituting a significant share of that growth. The transition to full LED perimeter systems, the introduction of virtual signage, and the development of premium signage inventory; LED stumps, dugout branding, on-screen overlays have each contributed to this revenue growth by expanding the commercial inventory available for sale and increasing the premium that premium inventory commands.

The impact of IPL branding and signage on fan engagement is equally significant and if harder to quantify directly. The visual richness and commercial polish of the IPL broadcast product; the high-quality LED signage, the illuminated stumps, the branded dugouts, the professional graphic overlays contributes to the overall production quality that makes watching an IPL match a visually engaging and entertainment-oriented experience. This production quality in turn drives the extraordinary viewership figures that sustain the league's commercial model.

Table 6.2: Key Signage Innovations in IPL and Their Commercial Significance

Innovation	Introduced	Description	Commercial Benefit
Full LED Perimeter	2010s (major rollout)	Dynamic rotating sponsor content	15+ sponsors per space
LED / Zing Stumps	2015 (international), IPL adoption	Illuminated stumps on dismissal	Broadcast-frame premium visibility
Branded Dugouts	Progressive, fully rolled out by 2018	Custom chairs, branded environment	High-visibility fan and broadcast space
Virtual On-Pitch Ads	2012 onwards	Digital overlays on pitch during breaks	Market-specific targeting
DNA LED Screening	2019 onwards	Modular LED across venue surfaces	Full venue branding, seamless visual

Innovation	Introduced	Description	Commercial Benefit
Boundary Rope Branding	2010 onwards	Logo placement on boundary marker	Constant wide-angle broadcast presence

Source: Researcher's own compilation from secondary data (ESPNcricinfo; SportsPro; Gold Coast Sport Signage references)

6.6 Key Insights

The IPL case study yields several insights that are directly relevant to the broader study of sports branding and signage evolution. First, the franchise model creates a multiplicative effect on commercial branding: instead of one league brand there are ten franchise brands, each generating its own branding and signage inventory while contributing to the central league brand. This model generates significantly more total commercial value than a centralised, non-franchise league structure.

Second, the integration of technology, particularly LED and virtual signage has been essential to the IPL's commercial growth. The league's willingness to invest in signage infrastructure both directly and through the enabling of franchise and venue upgrades has created the commercial density that sustains its extraordinary sponsorship revenues. Third, specialist branding agencies such as Gold Coast Sport Signage play an irreplaceable role in translating brand strategy into executed reality across the complex, multi-venue, multi-sponsor environment of a major cricket tournament.

CHAPTER 7: CASE STUDY 2 – ICC EVENTS

7.1 Overview of ICC Tournaments

The International Cricket Council (ICC) is the global governing body for cricket responsible for organising and managing the sport's premier international tournaments. The ICC's event portfolio includes the Men's Cricket World Cup (50-over format), the Men's T20 World Cup, the World Test Championship Final, the Champions Trophy, the Women's World Cup and Women's T20 World Cup and various under-age tournaments. These events collectively represent the pinnacle of the international cricket calendar and command some of the highest viewership figures in world sport.

The ICC's commercial model is built primarily around centralised rights, broadcast rights, sponsorship rights and event hosting rights that are sold globally and the revenues distributed among member boards according to an agreed formula. India, through the BCCI and the extraordinary size of its television audience receives the largest single share of ICC revenues, reflecting the commercial reality that Indian viewership is the primary driver of broadcast rights values for virtually every ICC event.

The scale of ICC events makes them among the most commercially significant signage and branding platforms in world sport. The 2023 ICC Cricket World Cup hosted in India attracted a cumulative television audience estimated at over one billion viewers across its matches. The final between India and Australia was watched by an estimated 300 million viewers in India alone, a number that dwarfs the audience for any other single sporting event outside of the FIFA World Cup and the Olympic Games.

7.2 Branding Strategy in ICC Events

The ICC's branding strategy for its events has undergone significant evolution over the past two decades. In its earlier manifestations, ICC branding was functional and administrative, the ICC logo, the event logo and the host nation's identity were the primary visual elements of the tournament brand. Commercial partnerships were present but not systematically managed in the way that would be expected of a contemporary major event.

The ICC's branding strategy became significantly more sophisticated with the appointment of professional event management and marketing teams in the 2000s and 2010s. Tournament brands now receive the same level of professional design and strategic management as major franchise sports properties. Each ICC event has a distinct visual identity such as the logo, colour palette, tagline, and mascot developed to communicate the unique character of the tournament while reinforcing the ICC's overarching brand values of excitement, excellence and global unity.

The ICC's Official Partner programme which represents the senior tier of ICC commercial relationships, includes global brands such as MRF Tyres, Oppo (subsequently replaced by Byju's and then other partners), Nissan and Coca-Cola. These partners receive comprehensive packages of brand entitlements across all ICC events worldwide including signage rights, broadcast exposure, digital and social media integrations and experiential activations at event venues. The ICC manages these partnerships through a structured category exclusivity system that ensures each partner brand receives meaningful differentiation from its competitors within the ICC commercial ecosystem.

Table 7.1: ICC Event Sponsorship and Branding Overview (Selected)

Tier	Description	Example Partners	Key Entitlements
Global Partner	Top-tier, all ICC events worldwide	TATA Group, MRF, Nissan	Full branding, signage, broadcast rights

Tier	Description	Example Partners	Key Entitlements
Official Sponsor	Major events, selected markets	Various regional brands	Perimeter signage, on-air integration
Official Supporter	Selected events or regions	Category-specific brands	Limited signage, digital exposure
Host Broadcaster Sponsor	Broadcast-specific packages	Regional commercial brands	Virtual signage, broadcast overlays

Source: Compiled from ICC official communications, SportsBusiness Journal (2024)

7.3 Signage Systems in ICC Events

The signage infrastructure deployed at ICC events reflects the organisation's ambition to deliver a consistent, premium, globally broadcast product regardless of the host nation or venue. The ICC's event operations team works with host boards and venues to ensure that signage systems meet international standards specifically that LED perimeter systems capable of supporting the ICC's commercial programme are installed at all primary venues.

For ICC events hosted in India, this has meant close coordination between the ICC, the BCCI, and specialist agencies such as Gold Coast Sport Signage, DNA Networks, Gameplan Sports ensure that the ICC's global branding requirements are met within the existing infrastructure of Indian cricket grounds. The ICC's signage guidelines govern the placement, size and content of all perimeter boards, outfield markings, and broadcast graphics across all event venues.

Virtual signage has become a cornerstone of the ICC's commercial model for international events. Given that ICC events are broadcast across the world to audiences with very different demographic profiles and commercial interests, the ability to deliver geographically targeted advertising through virtual signage is essential to maximising sponsorship revenues. An ICC World Cup broadcast to Indian viewers might carry one set of virtual pitch-side advertisements, while the same broadcast feed delivered to viewers in England carries an entirely different set each optimised for the commercial priorities of that market.

Stump branding at ICC events is a closely contested piece of commercial real estate. The stump sponsor at a major ICC tournament typically a high-profile global brand receives exposure in every broadcast frame that features the stumps, which constitutes the majority of delivery-by-delivery coverage throughout a match. The introduction of LED stumps into ICC events has added a dynamic visual element to this exposure, with the sponsor's association with the moment of dismissal one of the most memorable and frequently replayed moments in cricket adding significant value beyond simple brand visibility.

The ICC's approach to dugout branding at its events has also evolved. Player dressing rooms and team areas at ICC events are branded according to ICC guidelines, creating a consistent visual environment that reinforces the tournament identity while providing commercial exposure for ICC partners. The evolution from plain functional spaces to fully branded environments, equipped with premium seating and comprehensive visual branding, mirrors the transformation seen in the IPL context.

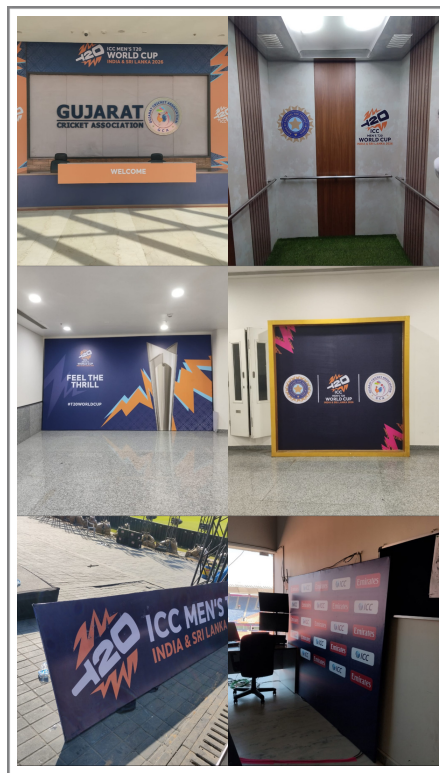
7.4 Global Impact

The global scale of ICC events creates both opportunities and challenges for branding and signage management that have no parallel in domestic cricket. Signage systems must perform consistently across venues on multiple continents, in varying climatic conditions, and in front of audiences with fundamentally different cultural and commercial contexts. The ICC's investment in standardised signage guidelines and event operations infrastructure represents a recognition that commercial consistency is essential to maintaining the premium value of ICC event sponsorship rights.

The ICC's global branding programme has significantly elevated the commercial profile of cricket as a worldwide sport. By managing event branding to professional international standards, the ICC has created a commercial platform that is attractive not only to cricket-

specific sponsors but to global brands in categories such as automotive, technology, finance and fast-moving consumer goods that seek to reach large, engaged, globally distributed audiences. The result has been a sustained increase in the value of ICC sponsorship rights and a broadening of the sponsor base from predominantly cricket-specific brands to genuinely global commercial partners.

The 2023 Cricket World Cup hosted in India provided a compelling example of ICC event branding and signage at scale. Ten venues across India hosted matches in a tournament that generated record viewership figures and set new commercial benchmarks for a cricket event outside of the IPL. The integration of BCCI and ICC branding requirements at these venues managed through close coordination between the ICC's event operations team and the BCCI's central branding arrangements demonstrated the complex, multi-stakeholder nature of modern cricket event branding.



CHAPTER 8: CASE STUDY 3 – ENGLISH PREMIER LEAGUE (EPL)

8.1 Overview of the League

The English Premier League is widely regarded as the most commercially successful domestic football league in the world. Launched in 1992 following the breakaway of England's top football clubs from the Football League, the Premier League rapidly established itself as a global sporting product of extraordinary reach and commercial value. Today the Premier League is broadcast in 188 countries and territories, reaches a cumulative global audience of over 3 billion viewers per season and generates annual revenues exceeding GBP 6 billion.

The commercial success of the Premier League has been built on a combination of compelling football, world-class players, globally recognised club brands and professional management of broadcasting and sponsorship rights. The league's central marketing organisation manages the Premier League brand, coordinates the league's central commercial partnerships and sets the standards for club branding and stadium signage that apply across all member clubs. Individual clubs retain their own commercial rights and manage their own sponsorships, creating a dual-layer commercial architecture in which league and club brands coexist and complement each other.

The Premier League's relevance to this study lies not only in its commercial scale but in its role as a pioneer and innovator in sports branding and signage practice. Many of the developments in sports signage and branding that are now standard across global sport were first systematically deployed or widely adopted in the Premier League context, including LED perimeter advertising, digital stadium branding, virtual pitch-side advertising and the use of social and digital media as brand-building platforms.

8.2 Branding Evolution in Football

The English Premier League's brand evolution over its three-decade history mirrors, in compressed form, the broader evolution of sports branding described in Chapter 3. At its launch in 1992, the league's visual identity was functional and relatively unsophisticated. The emphasis was on the football product itself rather than on a carefully managed league brand. Over the following decade, as broadcast revenues soared and global interest expanded, the Premier League invested progressively more in brand management.

The rebranding of the Premier League in 2016, which replaced the previous lion crest identity with a more contemporary and flexible lion badge design, was a significant indicator of the league's maturation as a brand management organisation. The new identity was designed to be more versatile across digital and physical applications, reflecting the growing importance of digital brand presence in the league's communications strategy.

Individual club branding in the Premier League has followed a similar trajectory. Clubs like Manchester United, Liverpool, Chelsea, Arsenal and Manchester City have invested heavily in brand management, recognising that their brand equity, built on decades of success, supporter loyalty, and global media exposure and is one of their most valuable commercial assets. Manchester United's global brand value has been estimated at over USD 1 billion, making it one of the world's most valuable sports brands by any measure.

The athlete branding dimension is particularly developed in football. Players like Cristiano Ronaldo and Lionel Messi have built personal brands of extraordinary commercial value, with global endorsement portfolios that intersect with but extend well beyond their club affiliations. In the Premier League context, the personal brands of individual players contribute significantly to the commercial profile of their clubs, a player of Ronaldo's commercial stature elevates the brand visibility of any club he joins.

Digital and social media have become central to Premier League club branding strategies. Clubs like Chelsea, Arsenal, Manchester City and Liverpool maintain social media followings of tens of millions, delivering content in multiple languages to global fan communities. The use of social media for behind-the-scenes content, player access and fan engagement has been one of the most significant developments in football club branding over the past decade.

8.3 Signage Technologies in EPL Stadiums

English Premier League stadiums have been at the forefront of sports signage technology deployment in European football. The adoption of LED perimeter advertising systems began in English football in the late 1990s and early 2000s and is now universal across Premier League grounds. Every Premier League stadium operates a full-perimeter LED system capable of delivering dynamic, broadcast-optimised content in synchronisation with the match broadcast.

The Premier League's stadium signage market is worth hundreds of millions of pounds annually. Individual clubs manage their own signage rights, selling packages to sponsors that include perimeter board exposure, digital scoreboard advertising, concourse and hospitality signage and increasingly, virtual pitch-side advertising visible in broadcast. The diversity and sophistication of stadium signage inventory available in Premier League venues, a product of decades of investment and refinement, is among the most developed of any sports league in the world.

Giant video screens at Premier League grounds have evolved from simple scoreboards to multi-functional media platforms that deliver match replays, statistical information, commercial content and fan entertainment throughout match day. The visual quality of these installations measured in pixel pitch and brightness levels has improved dramatically over the past decade, driven by advances in LED technology and an increasing emphasis on the quality of the in-stadium viewer experience.

Naming rights; the practice of selling the right to name a stadium after a sponsor represent a distinctive form of stadium branding that is well established in English football. Emirates Stadium (Arsenal), Tottenham Hotspur Stadium's naming discussions and Brentford Community Stadium are among the many Premier League venues where naming rights have been or are being commercially managed. These arrangements generate significant annual revenues for the clubs concerned and represent the most pervasive form of commercial branding in the stadium environment.

8.4 Virtual Advertising in Football

Virtual advertising technology the digital overlay of sponsor brand images onto the live television broadcast has been widely adopted in Premier League broadcasts and represents one of the most commercially innovative applications of signage technology in global football. The technology allows clubs and the league to sell pitch-side advertising space to multiple sponsors simultaneously across different broadcast markets, dramatically increasing the total commercial yield of the available inventory.

The economic rationale for virtual advertising in the Premier League is particularly compelling given the league's global broadcast footprint. A single match broadcast simultaneously to audiences in the United Kingdom, the United States, Asia, the Middle East and dozens of other markets represents an opportunity to deliver different sponsor messages to each audience, maximising the commercial value of each viewer impression. Brands with regional rather than global marketing objectives can purchase virtual advertising for specific markets at a fraction of the cost of a global pitch-side deal, making the Premier League's commercial platform accessible to a wider range of sponsor categories.

The use of virtual advertising in the Premier League has been driven by specialist technology companies that provide the camera-tracking and image-processing systems required for seamless digital overlay. Companies such as Supponor and Viz RT have developed virtual advertising

solutions specifically for football broadcasts, working with clubs and broadcasters to integrate the technology into existing production infrastructure. The sophistication of these systems has advanced to the point where virtual advertising is virtually indistinguishable from physical pitch-side signage to the television viewer; a testimony to the precision of modern camera-tracking and image-compositing technology.

Beyond pitch-side virtual advertising, the Premier League has also seen the development of virtual shirt sponsorship technology the ability to digitally replace the sponsor logo on a player's jersey for different broadcast markets. While this application remains more technically challenging than pitch-side virtual advertising and has not yet been widely deployed commercially, it represents the frontier of virtual branding technology in sports and is likely to become a significant commercial tool in the coming years.

CHAPTER 9: COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS

9.1 IPL vs ICC vs Football Leagues – Branding

The three case studies examined in this project the Indian Premier League, ICC international events and the English Premier League represent three different but complementary models of sports branding, each with its own distinct logic, scale and commercial architecture.

The IPL's branding model is franchise-centred with multiple independent team brands existing within a central league brand. This creates a layered commercial ecosystem in which fans, sponsors and media partners can engage with the sport at multiple levels simultaneously as supporters of a particular franchise as fans of the overall IPL product and as consumers of the individual player brands that populate the league. The IPL's branding success is inseparable from this franchise structure, which generates a multiplicity of commercially compelling identities that would be impossible under a centralised model.

The ICC's branding model is event-centred with each tournament presenting a distinct brand identity the Cricket World Cup, the T20 World Cup, the Champions Trophy within the overarching ICC institutional brand. This model is designed for a global audience with diverse cultural and commercial contexts and its success depends on the ICC's ability to create event brands that translate effectively across multiple markets simultaneously. The ICC's branding is necessarily more conservative and universally accessible than the edgier, more locally specific branding of IPL franchises.

The English Premier League's branding model is club-centred, with the most commercially powerful entities in the system being the individual clubs rather than the league itself. This reflects the deeper historical roots of the club identities and the primacy of club loyalty in

English football culture. The Premier League brand functions primarily as a quality mark and commercial organiser rather than as a primary fan-facing identity.

9.2 IPL vs ICC vs Football Leagues – Signage

In terms of signage technology and practice all three properties have reached broadly comparable levels of sophistication, deploying full LED perimeter systems, virtual advertising capabilities, and integrated broadcast signage. The differences between them lie more in the specific applications of these technologies and the commercial models through which signage inventory is managed and monetised.

The IPL's signage model is distinguished by its central management through specialist agencies, the depth of its broadcast integration (particularly through stump branding, virtual pitch advertising and dugout branding) and the extraordinary commercial density it achieves; more sponsor brands visible per hour of broadcast than arguably any other comparable sporting event. The role of Gold Coast Sport Signage in creating and maintaining this commercial density across multiple venues is a distinctive feature of the IPL model.

The ICC's signage model is distinguished by its global standardisation requirements ensuring consistent commercial delivery across diverse venues in multiple host nations and its use of virtual signage for geographic market segmentation. The ICC faces a challenge that neither the IPL nor the Premier League faces in the same form: delivering a consistent commercial product across venues in South Asia, the Caribbean, Australia, England and beyond each with different infrastructure, different regulatory environments and different broadcast audiences.

The Premier League's signage model is distinguished by the maturity of its technology infrastructure and the sophistication of its virtual advertising applications. English football stadiums, having been investing in LED and digital signage for longer than most cricket venues,

tend to have more refined and technically advanced systems. The Premier League's global broadcast footprint also makes it one of the most commercially valuable virtual advertising platforms in world sport.

Table 9.1: Comparative Analysis – IPL vs ICC Events vs English Premier League

Parameter	IPL	ICC Events	English Premier League
Branding Model	Franchise-centred	Event-centred, global	Club-centred
Primary Audience	India + diaspora	Global cricket markets	Global, UK primary
Signage Technology	LED + virtual + LED stumps	LED + virtual, standardised	LED + virtual + naming rights
Central Signage Agency	Gold Coast Sport Signage, DNA	TCM, DNA	Club-managed, external vendors
Dugout Branding	Advanced – branded game chairs	Standard, ICC-regulated	Varied by club
Stump Branding	LED stumps, high value	Premium, LED stumps in major events	Not applicable
Virtual Signage	Pitch overlays, geo-targeted	Global market targeting	Pitch-side, shirt (emerging)
Revenue Scale	INR 15,000+ crore/season	USD 2+ billion/cycle (World Cup)	GBP 6+ billion/season

Source: Researcher's own compilation from secondary data (Nielsen Sports, Deloitte, ESPNcricinfo, Premier League, 2024)

9.3 Key Learnings

The comparative analysis of these three case studies yields several key learnings that are broadly applicable to sports management practitioners working in the branding and signage space.

The first learning is that commercial success in sports branding is inseparable from the quality of the brand architecture, the structural design of how individual entity brands (teams, players, events) relate to each other and to the overarching property brand. The IPL's franchise model and the Premier League's club model both create commercial value by generating multiple independently compelling brands within a single commercial system.

The second learning is that signage technology investment is a direct enabler of commercial revenue growth. In each of the three case studies, periods of significant commercial revenue growth have been associated with upgrades in signage technology, the adoption of LED systems, the deployment of virtual advertising, the development of new signage categories such as stump branding and dugout branding. The return on investment in signage infrastructure is high when the resulting inventory is managed and monetised effectively.

The third learning is that the integration of branding and signage requires specialist expertise that is distinct from general marketing or event management capability. The role of specialist agencies such as Gold Coast Sport Signage, DNA Networks organisations that combine deep technical knowledge of signage systems with understanding of brand strategy and commercial rights management is essential to achieving the level of integration that generates premium commercial outcomes.

CHAPTER 10: FUTURE TRENDS

10.1 AI and Data-Driven Branding

Artificial intelligence is beginning to reshape sports branding in ways that would have seemed futuristic even a decade ago. AI-powered analytics platforms can now process vast quantities of fan data; social media behaviour, viewing patterns, merchandise purchase history, app engagement to generate granular insights into fan preferences, attitudes and commercial behaviours. These insights are enabling sports brands to move from broad-based communications strategies toward highly personalised brand interactions that are tailored to the specific interests and behaviours of individual fans.

In the signage space, AI is enabling the development of smart signage systems that can automatically optimise content in response to real-time data inputs; audience composition, match situation, weather conditions, social media trends. An AI-powered signage system at a major cricket stadium might automatically switch to displaying a cold beverage sponsor's advertisement when temperature sensors indicate an unusually hot day or prioritise a particular sponsor's message during high-viewing-intensity moments such as a tense final over. This level of intelligent, context-responsive content management represents a significant evolution beyond the scheduled content rotation that characterises current LED systems.

AI is also being applied to sponsorship valuation and measurement. Traditional approaches to measuring the value of sponsor exposure, counting seconds of broadcast visibility and multiplying by equivalent advertising rates are being supplemented by AI-powered image recognition systems that can automatically identify and measure every instance of brand exposure across all broadcast and digital channels simultaneously. These systems provide rights-

holders and sponsors with far more comprehensive and accurate valuation data than was previously possible, enabling more evidence-based commercial negotiations.

10.2 Virtual and Personalised Advertising

The virtual signage technology described in previous chapters is itself continuing to evolve rapidly. Current virtual signage systems can deliver different brand messages to different geographic markets simultaneously but future systems will be capable of even finer-grained targeting potentially delivering different messages to individual viewers based on their personal profiles, viewing history and behavioural data. This degree of personalisation applied to sports broadcast advertising would represent the convergence of sports signage with the personalisation technology already deployed in online advertising.

The development of virtual shirt sponsorship technology replacing the physical sponsor logo on a player's jersey with a different digital logo for each broadcast market is a particularly significant frontier. If fully realised, this technology would create an entirely new category of sports signage inventory allowing multiple brands to occupy the same physical shirt space simultaneously across different markets. The commercial implications would be transformative: shirt sponsorship, currently one of the highest-value and most constrained categories of sports signage would become infinitely expandable.

10.3 Immersive Fan Experiences (AR / VR)

Augmented Reality and Virtual Reality technologies are creating new possibilities for sports branding and fan engagement that extend well beyond the traditional boundaries of venue or broadcast signage. AR applications on smartphones already allow fans at grounds to overlay additional information like player statistics, sponsor offers, interactive mini-games onto their physical environment by pointing their devices at specific locations within the venue. As AR

glasses and wearable devices become mainstream consumer products, these capabilities will become available without the friction of holding up a smartphone.

Virtual Reality offers the possibility of entirely immersive sports experiences watching a match from any seat in the ground or from perspectives entirely unavailable to physical spectators such as the umpire's end or a high aerial viewpoint. In this immersive environment, branding and signage can be integrated in ways that are far more sophisticated and engaging than a traditional perimeter board. A virtual spectator's experience of the stadium environment including all branding elements can be individually customised, opening new frontiers for personalised sponsor engagement.

The convergence of these technologies with sports branding is still in its early stages but the direction of travel is clear. The sports fan's experience whether in-stadium on broadcast or in digital spaces will become progressively more immersive more personalised and more commercially rich. Sports brands and signage providers that anticipate and adapt to these trends will be well positioned to capture the commercial opportunities they create.

CHAPTER 11: CONCLUSION

11.1 Summary of Findings

This study set out to trace and analyse the evolution of sports branding and sports signage in modern sporting events and to examine how these two related but distinct disciplines have developed in response to technological change, commercial imperatives and the globalisation of sport. The findings, drawn from a comprehensive review of secondary literature and three detailed case studies confirm that both disciplines have undergone transformations of extraordinary depth and pace over the course of the past half-century.

Sports branding has evolved from a simple system of visual identification for teams and clubs into a sophisticated, strategically managed commercial discipline that operates across physical, broadcast and digital platforms simultaneously. This evolution has been driven by the growth of television broadcasting in the latter half of the twentieth century, the globalisation of major sports leagues and events and the emergence of digital and social media as primary channels of fan engagement and commercial communication. Today the most successful sports brands the IPL franchises, the Premier League clubs, the ICC's tournament properties are managed with the same strategic rigour as the world's leading consumer brands, and their brand equity represents a significant proportion of their total commercial value.

Sports signage has evolved from hand-painted boards and printed hoardings through successive technological generations such as backlit panels, inlit gate items, LED perimeter systems, giant big screens, virtual broadcast overlays and smart data-driven displays, each of which has expanded the commercial capabilities of the medium and the revenue it generates for rights-holders and sponsors. The introduction of LED technology multiplied the commercial inventory available per venue; virtual signage decoupled physical space from commercial value, enabling

geographic market segmentation and smart signage technology is beginning to enable real-time, context-sensitive brand communication of unprecedented sophistication.

The IPL case study demonstrates perhaps more vividly than any other example how the integration of advanced branding and signage strategies can transform a new sporting property into a commercial phenomenon of global significance within a remarkably short period. The role of specialist agencies such as Gold Coast Sport Signage the BCCI's central branding partner in designing and executing the integrated visual environments that underpin the IPL's commercial model illustrates the critical importance of specialist expertise in translating brand strategy into commercial reality.

The ICC and EPL case studies demonstrate that the principles of integrated branding and signage excellence transcend any single sport or market. Whether in the context of a global cricket tournament delivered to a billion viewers or a domestic football league broadcast across 188 countries, the fundamental commercial logic is the same: well-managed brands, supported by sophisticated signage infrastructure, create value for rights-holders, sponsors and fans alike.

11.2 Final Insights

The central insight that emerges from this study is that sports branding and sports signage are not separate disciplines but two dimensions of a single integrated commercial system. Understanding them in isolation is insufficient for practitioners who wish to work effectively in the contemporary sports industry. The sports manager of the future must be conversant with brand strategy and creative identity but equally with the technology platforms through which those strategies are executed like the LED systems, the virtual advertising technology, the data analytics tools that now underpin the commercial operations of major sporting events.

The Indian sports industry anchored by cricket and the IPL is at the forefront of this integration. The BCCI's investment in professional branding and signage infrastructure has created a commercial ecosystem that rivals the most sophisticated sports markets in the world. For students and practitioners of sports management in India, understanding this ecosystem its history, its commercial logic and its technological foundations is not merely an academic exercise but a professional necessity.

As the industry continues to evolve driven by AI, virtual reality, personalised advertising and the ever-expanding reach of digital media the opportunities for innovation in sports branding and signage will only grow. The organisations and the individuals, who combine strategic vision with technological literacy and commercial creativity will be best placed to seize those opportunities and shape the next chapter of this remarkable story.



BIBLIOGRAPHY

Board of Control for Cricket in India. (2024). IPL media rights and commercial overview. BCCI Official Communications.

Boyle, R., & Haynes, R. (2009). Power play: Sport, the media and popular culture (2nd ed.). Edinburgh University Press.

Deloitte Sports Business Group. (2024). Annual review of football finance 2024. Deloitte.

Desbordes, M., & Richelieu, A. (Eds.). (2012). Global sport marketing: Contemporary issues and practice. Routledge.

ESPNcricinfo. (2024). IPL commercial data and franchise valuations. ESPN Digital Media.

International Cricket Council. (2024). ICC commercial programme overview. ICC Official Publications.

Kotler, P., & Keller, K. L. (2016). Marketing management (15th ed.). Pearson Education.

Mullin, B. J., Hardy, S., & Sutton, W. A. (2014). Sport marketing (4th ed.). Human Kinetics.

Nielsen Sports. (2023). The value of sports sponsorship: Global benchmarks report 2023. Nielsen Holdings.

Premier League. (2024). Premier League commercial overview and broadcast rights. Premier League Official Publications.

PricewaterhouseCoopers. (2024). Sports outlook 2024. PwC Global.

SportsPro Media. (2023). The world's 50 most marketable athletes 2023. SportsPro.

Statista. (2024). Global sports market revenue 2011–2030. Statista Research Department. <https://www.statista.com>

Supponor. (2023). Virtual advertising in sports broadcasting: Technology and commercial applications. Supponor Ltd.